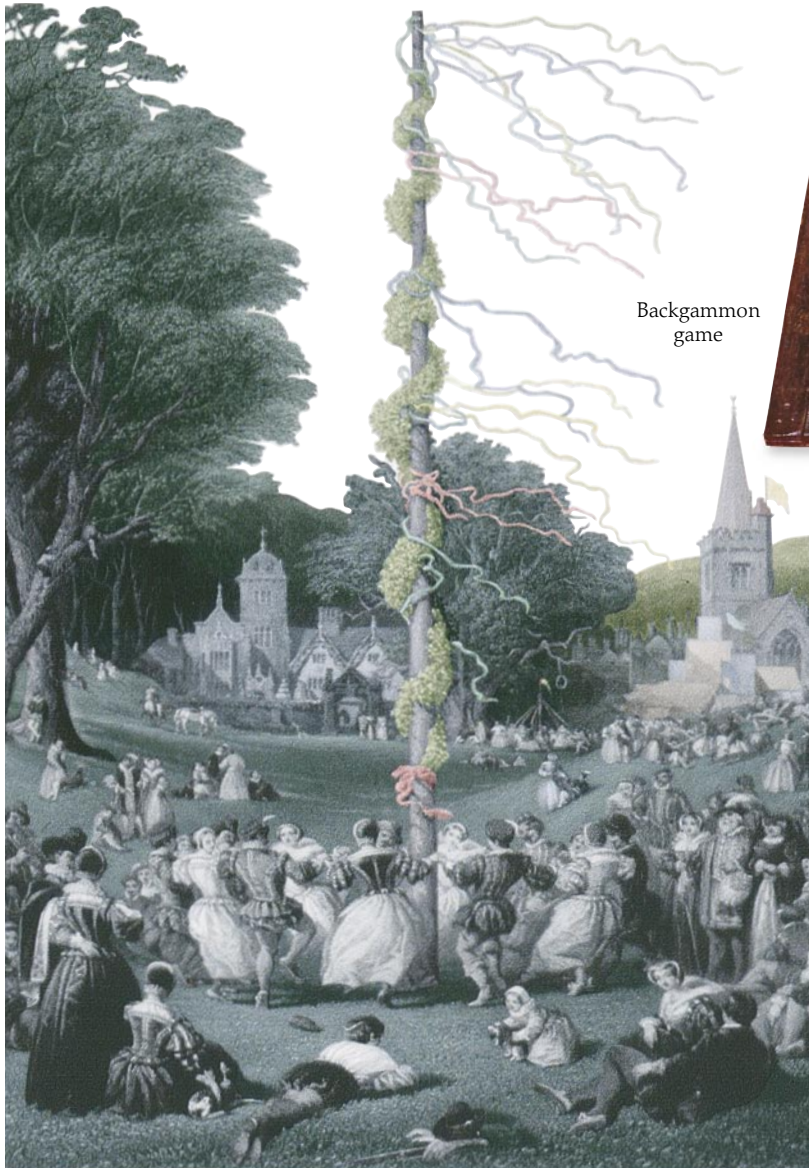


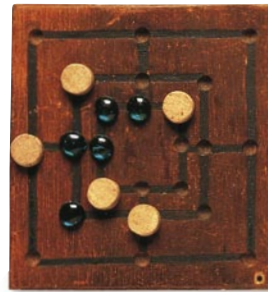


Backgammon game

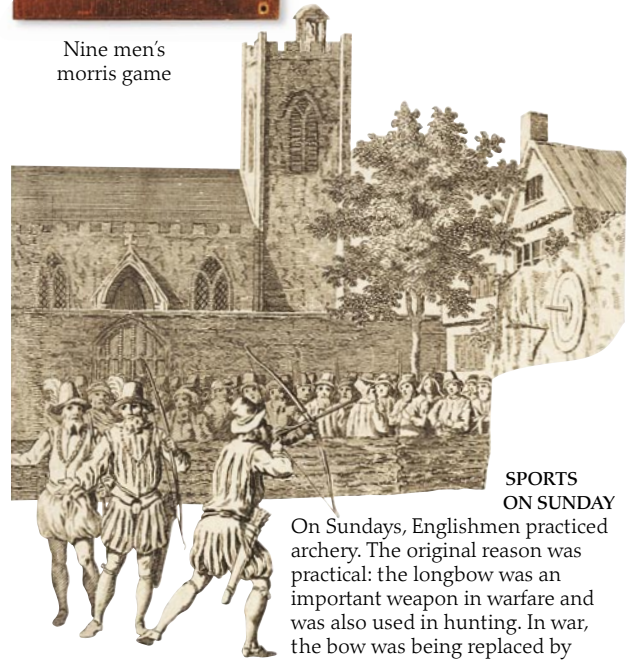


RICH GAME, POOR GAME

Shakespeare mentions two board games in his plays: tables, or backgammon, which was played by the wealthy; and nine men's morris, which was played by the poor. Shepherds often cut the lines of the morris board in the ground and played with pebbles.



Nine men's morris game



SPORTS ON SUNDAY

On Sundays, Englishmen practiced archery. The original reason was practical: the longbow was an important weapon in warfare and was also used in hunting. In war, the bow was being replaced by firearms, but archery remained a popular sport. The queen herself was a skilled archer.

Gentlemen shoot arrows at a target on the village green

SUMMER CELEBRATIONS

On May 1, people celebrated the arrival of summer by dancing around poles that were decked with flowers and ribbons, called maypoles. Collecting blossoms to hang over doors, or "going-a-maying," was another Maytime custom. In *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, Shakespeare writes: "They rose early to observe the rite of May."



Games and festivals

Although country people worked hard, at quiet times in the farming year they found time for games and sports, such as nine men's morris, football, cockfighting, and archery. There were also festivals throughout the year to celebrate the changing seasons, religious events, and other special occasions, such as royal visits.

ENTERTAINING ROYALTY

The most exciting event in the countryside was a visit from Queen Elizabeth. The local nobility spent vast sums of money on the entertainment, such as this water show, put on for her in 1591. Elizabeth spent much of her time traveling around England, and people in the countryside looked forward to seeing her.